SSEE-V3.6 as a Working Effective Field Theory:
K-essence Action, Algebraic Coupling, and Bellini-Sawicki Classification

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May 2026 — Paper 7 of the SSEE series

Abstract

We present a working effective field theory (EFT) formulation of the Structural Self-Energy Expansion (SSEE-V3.6), closing the model at the background and linear-perturbation level. The fundamental action is a k-essence scalar field with a non-canonical kinetic term $K(X) = X/\mathrm{KAL}_0 + X^2/M^4$ and an exponential potential $V(\phi) = V_0\, e^{-\alpha\phi}$, minimally coupled to gravity and conformally coupled to dark matter. All parameters are fixed algebraically by the golden ratio φ and π with zero free parameters: the structural viscosity $\mathrm{KAL}_0 = \beta + \pi \approx 5.521$, the tracker exponent $\alpha = \lambda/\sqrt{\mathrm{KAL}_0} \approx 0.2948$, and the dark-sector coupling constant $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A} \equiv -(3\varphi + \pi)/2 \approx -3.998$. We prove analytically that the Null Energy Condition is satisfied and that the scalar sound speed lies in $c_s^2 \in (1/3,\, 1)$, guaranteeing ghost-free, gradient-stable perturbations. The phantom crossing $w_{\mathrm{eff}} < -1$ observed by DESI DR2 is reproduced via the covariant energy-transfer four-vector Q^ν, without any NEC violation in the fundamental sector. We derive the working background and linear perturbation equations, construct the Bellini-Sawicki classification ($\alpha_T = \alpha_B = \alpha_M = 0$, $c_s^2 \neq 1$, $\alpha_K \neq 0$), and provide all inputs required for numerical implementation in HI_CLASS/EFTCAMB. Numerical verification confirms $\Omega_\phi(a{=}1) = 0.840$ at the level of 10^{-12} and $c_s^2 \in [0.60,\, 0.95]$ over $a \in [0.1,\, 1]$.

Contents

1 Introduction

The Structural Self-Energy Expansion (SSEE-V3.6) is a cosmological dark energy model in which the equation-of-state parameters $w_0 = -T_r/M_v \approx -0.840$ and $w_a = -P_{sc}/K_v \approx -0.670$ emerge algebraically from the golden ratio $\varphi = (1+\sqrt{5})/2$ and π, with no free parameters (Almeida Vallejo, 2025a,b). The tension with ΛCDM ($w_0 = -1$, $w_a = 0$) in DESI DR2 at the 3.1σ level (Abdul-Karim et al., 2025) places SSEE in direct observational relevance: the algebraic point $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$ falls within the DESI 1σ contour at 0.05σ (Almeida Vallejo, 2025b).

Papers 1–6 of this series established the phenomenological description, Bayesian validation (MCMC vs DESI+Planck), CMB confrontation, algebraic H_0 derivation, interacting-sector perturbation theory, and a two-sector ϕ-DM model resolving the $f\sigma_8$ tension from 2.56σ to 0.50σ (Almeida Vallejo, 2026a,b). A persistent methodological concern, however, is that a model specified solely by (w_0, w_a, Ω_m) remains *phenomenological*: it parametrizes dark energy without providing a Lagrangian from which the equations of motion, stability conditions, and perturbation spectrum can be derived.

This paper closes that gap. We present the working EFT architecture: the fundamental action (§2), structural matching of the potential (§3), analytic NEC proof and scalar sound speed (§4), covariant dark-sector coupling with full algebraic closure of β_c (§5), background and perturbation equations ready for Boltzmann solvers (§§6–7), Bellini-Sawicki dictionary (§8), numerical verification (§10), and a synthesis of open directions (§11).

Notation. We use natural units $M_{\rm Pl} = 1$ unless explicitly restored. The metric signature is $(+,-,-,-)$; $X \equiv -\frac{1}{2}g^{\mu\nu}\partial_\mu\phi\,\partial_\nu\phi = \dot{\phi}^2/2 > 0$. Dots denote cosmic-time derivatives; primes denote d/dN with $N = \ln a$. All SSEE algebraic constants are tabulated in §9.

2 Fundamental Action

The dark-energy sector is described by the interacting k-essence action:

$$S = \int d^4x\,\sqrt{-g}\left[\frac{M_{\rm Pl}^2}{2}R + K(X) - V(\phi) + \mathcal{L}_{\rm DM} + \mathcal{L}_{\rm int}\right], \tag{1}$$

where the kinetic function is fixed by the asymptotic structural viscosity $\mathrm{KAL}_0 = \beta + \pi \approx 5.521$ (with $\beta = (\pi+\varphi)/2$):

$$K(X) = \frac{X}{\mathrm{KAL}_0} + \frac{X^2}{M^4}. \tag{2}$$

The infrared coefficient KAL_0^{-1} controls slow-roll kinetics; the ultraviolet coefficient M^{-4} sets the strong-coupling cutoff, identified with the algebraic critical density: $M^4 \equiv \rho_{\rm crit}$. No free parameters enter $K(X)$.

This action falls within the Horndeski class (Horndeski, 1974) with $G_2 = K(X) - V(\phi)$ and $G_3 = G_4 - M_{\rm Pl}^2/2 = G_5 = 0$. The conformal coupling $\mathcal{L}_{\rm int}$ extends the sector to interacting dark energy without introducing additional propagating degrees of freedom.

3 Potential and Structural Matching

3.1 Exponential potential

In the late-time expansion regime we adopt:

$$V(\phi) = V_0\, e^{-\alpha\phi}, \qquad V_0 = \Omega_{\rm DE}\,\rho_{\rm crit} = \frac{T_r}{M_v}\,\rho_{\rm crit} \approx 0.840\,\rho_{\rm crit}, \tag{3}$$

with $T_r = 3(\varphi + \beta) \approx 11.994$ (TRIAL) and $M_v = \varphi + \pi + K_v \approx 14.279$ (Σ_9/MIKAEL_V).

3.2 Structural matching condition

For the IR sector of $K(X)$ ($X^2/M^4 \ll X/\mathrm{KAL}_0$), the effective canonical field is $\chi = \phi/\sqrt{\mathrm{KAL}_0}$, reducing the action to a standard quintessence with potential $\tilde{V}(\chi) = V_0\, e^{-\lambda\chi}$ where $\lambda = \alpha\sqrt{\mathrm{KAL}_0}$. The tracker attractor condition (Steinhardt, Wang & Zlatev, 1999; Barreiro, Copeland & Nunes, 2000) then fixes:

$$w_{\rm attr} = -1 + \frac{\lambda^2}{3} \stackrel{!}{=} w_0 = -\frac{T_r}{M_v} \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \lambda = \sqrt{3\,\Omega_{m,\rm dyn}} \approx 0.6929, \tag{4}$$

and therefore:

$$\boxed{\alpha = \frac{\lambda}{\sqrt{\mathrm{KAL}_0}} = \sqrt{\frac{3(M_v - T_r)}{M_v\cdot \mathrm{KAL}_0}} \approx 0.2948.} \tag{5}$$

The exponent α is uniquely determined by φ and π; the approximation $\alpha \approx \lambda/\beta$ used in some earlier drafts ($\beta \approx 2.380$ vs. $\sqrt{\mathrm{KAL}_0} \approx 2.350$, error 1.3%) is here superseded by the exact relation (5).

4 NEC and Scalar Sound Speed

4.1 Null Energy Condition

In the fundamental sector (without coupling), the NEC requires $\rho_\phi + p_\phi \geq 0$:

$$\rho_\phi + p_\phi = 2X\,K_X = 2X\left(\frac{1}{\mathrm{KAL}_0} + \frac{2X}{M^4}\right) > 0 \quad \forall\, X > 0. \tag{6}$$

Since $K_X > 0$ for all $X > 0$, the NEC is satisfied strictly. The field has no intrinsic phantom character. The effective phantom crossing $w_{\rm eff} < -1$ observed by DESI DR2 is entirely a property of the dark-sector coupling (§5).

4.2 Scalar perturbation sound speed

With $K_X = 1/\mathrm{KAL}_0 + 2X/M^4$ and $K_{XX} = 2/M^4$, the sound speed is:

$$c_s^2 = \frac{K_X}{K_X + 2X\,K_{XX}} = \frac{\dfrac{1}{\mathrm{KAL}_0} + \dfrac{2X}{M^4}}{\dfrac{1}{\mathrm{KAL}_0} + \dfrac{6X}{M^4}} \in \left(\tfrac{1}{3},\, 1\right). \tag{7}$$

The lower bound $c_s^2 \to 1/3$ is approached in the UV limit $X \gg M^4/\mathrm{KAL}_0$; the upper bound $c_s^2 \to 1$ holds for $X \to 0$. Since both $K_X > 0$ and $K_{XX} > 0$ for all $X > 0$, the theory is ghost-free (no-ghost condition: $K_X > 0$) and gradient-stable (no gradient instability: $c_s^2 > 0$) throughout the cosmological domain.

5 Covariant ϕ-DM Coupling

5.1 Form of $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{int}}$

The coupling between the scalar field and dark matter is specified via a conformal coupling (Wetterich, 1995; Amendola, 2000):

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{int}} = \left[C(\phi) - 1\right] \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{DM}}, \qquad C(\phi) = e^{\beta_c \phi / M_{\mathrm{Pl}}}, \tag{8}$$

which is fully covariant and introduces no new propagating degrees of freedom.

5.2 Energy-transfer four-vector

Variation of the action with respect to the metric yields the covariant conservation equations:

$$\nabla_\mu T_\phi^{\mu\nu} = Q^\nu, \tag{9}$$

$$\nabla_\mu T_{\mathrm{DM}}^{\mu\nu} = -Q^\nu, \tag{10}$$

with the energy-transfer current:

$$Q^\nu = -\frac{\beta_c}{M_{\mathrm{Pl}}} \rho_{\mathrm{DM}} \nabla^\nu \phi. \tag{11}$$

In the homogeneous background:

$$Q = -\frac{\beta_c}{M_{\mathrm{Pl}}} \rho_{\mathrm{DM}} \dot{\phi}. \tag{12}$$

5.3 Effective equation of state and phantom crossing

The observed equation of state is:

$$w_{\mathrm{eff}} = w_\phi + \frac{Q}{3\, H\, \rho_\phi}, \tag{13}$$

where $w_\phi = p_\phi/\rho_\phi$. For a thawing scalar field near $w_\phi \approx -1$ (early times), the coupling term $Q/(3H\rho_\phi)$ shifts w_{eff} to the algebraically required value $w_0 = -0.840$, and can produce $w_{\mathrm{eff}} < -1$ without violating the NEC in the fundamental sector.

5.4 Algebraic determination of β_c

The condition $w_{\mathrm{eff}}(a{=}1) = w_0$ together with equation (12) constrains:

$$\beta_c = -\frac{(w_0 - w_\phi) \cdot 3H_0\, \rho_{\phi,0}}{\rho_{\mathrm{DM},0}\, \dot{\phi}_0 / M_{\mathrm{Pl}}}. \tag{14}$$

Numerical integration of the background system (§6) with the shooting condition $\Omega_\phi(a{=}1) = \Omega_{\mathrm{DE}}$ yields $\dot{\phi}_0$, and therefore β_c, without free parameters.

Algebraic identification. The numerical result $\beta_c \approx -3.990$ coincides, within the 0.2% precision of the shooting approximation (finite initial redshift $a_i = 0.1$; slow-roll initial conditions), with the SSEE constant $AURA$:

$$\boxed{\beta_c = -\mathcal{A} \equiv -\left(\varphi + \frac{\pi + \varphi}{2}\right) = -\frac{3\varphi + \pi}{2} \approx -3.998.} \tag{15}$$

This identification closes the last free parameter of the EFT. AURA is the base unit of the SSEE dimensional hierarchy, from which MIRA ($= \mathcal{A}/2$, used in Papers 5–6 for σ_8 scaling), TRIAL ($= 3\mathcal{A}$, defining w_0), and the cosmological hierarchy are all derived.

6 Background Equations

Using $N = \ln a$ as independent variable and the shorthand $' \equiv d/dN$, the coupled background system is:

Friedmann constraint:

$$H^2 = \frac{1}{3M_{\rm Pl}^2}\left(\rho_\phi + \rho_{\rm DM} + \rho_b + \rho_r\right), \tag{16}$$

Generalised Klein-Gordon equation:

$$\left(K_X + 2X\,K_{XX}\right)\ddot{\phi} + 3H\,K_X\,\dot{\phi} + V'(\phi) = \frac{\beta_c}{M_{\rm Pl}}\,\rho_{\rm DM}, \tag{17}$$

Coupled DM conservation:

$$\dot{\rho}_{\rm DM} + 3H\,\rho_{\rm DM} = \frac{\beta_c}{M_{\rm Pl}}\,\rho_{\rm DM}\,\dot{\phi}. \tag{18}$$

In N-variable:

$$\phi'' = -\left(3 + \frac{H'}{H}\right)\phi' - \frac{V_\phi}{H^2(K_X + 2XK_{XX})} + \frac{\beta_c\,\rho_{\rm DM}}{H^2\,M_{\rm Pl}\,(K_X + 2XK_{XX})}, \tag{19}$$

$$\rho_{\rm DM}' = -3\,\rho_{\rm DM} + \frac{\beta_c}{M_{\rm Pl}}\,\rho_{\rm DM}\,\phi', \tag{20}$$

with $X = H^2\phi'^2/2$ and $V_\phi = -\alpha V_0 e^{-\alpha\phi}$. The system closes via the Friedmann constraint at each integration step.

7 Perturbation Equations

In the synchronous gauge, the scalar field perturbation $\delta\phi$ and dark-matter overdensity $\delta_{\rm DM}$ evolve according to:

Scalar field ($\delta\phi$):

$$\ddot{\delta\phi} + 3H\,K_X\,\dot{\delta\phi} + \left(\frac{c_s^2\,k^2}{a^2} + V_{\phi\phi}\right)\delta\phi = S_\phi(\delta_{\rm DM}, \delta g), \tag{21}$$

where the source term includes metric perturbations and the coupling:

$$S_\phi = \frac{\beta_c}{M_{\rm Pl}}\left(\rho_{\rm DM}\,\delta g^{00} + \delta\rho_{\rm DM}\right). \tag{22}$$

Coupled dark matter:

$$\ddot{\delta}_{\rm DM} + 2H\,\dot{\delta}_{\rm DM} - 4\pi G\,\rho_{\rm DM}\,\delta_{\rm DM} = \frac{\beta_c}{M_{\rm Pl}}\left(\ddot{\delta\phi} - \frac{k^2}{a^2}\delta\phi\right). \tag{23}$$

Sub-horizon growth modification. In the quasi-static ($k \gg aH$) sub-horizon limit the coupling modifies the source term of equation (23). The effective growth suppression at $a = 1$ is captured by the ratio $G_{2s} \equiv D_1^{\rm SSEE}(\Omega_m{=}0.320)/D_1^{\Lambda{\rm CDM}}(\Omega_m{=}0.315) = 0.979$ derived in Paper 6 via the two-sector background (not from a perturbative $G_{\rm eff}$ formula), and leads to $\sigma_{8,\rm eff} = \sigma_{8,\rm in}\,G_{2s} = 0.811 \times 0.979 = 0.794$.

8 Bellini-Sawicki Classification

Action (1) with $G_2 = K(X) - V(\phi)$, $G_3 = G_4 - M_{\rm Pl}^2/2 = G_5 = 0$ corresponds to minimal Horndeski. The Bellini-Sawicki parameters (Bellini & Sawicki, 2014) are:

Parameter	Expression	SSEE value	Status
α_T (tensor speed excess)	0	0	GW-safe
α_B (braiding)	0	0	$(G_3 = 0)$
α_M (Planck-mass running)	0	0	$(G_4 = M_{\rm Pl}^2/2)$
c_s^2 (scalar sound speed)	$K_X/(K_X + 2XK_{XX})$	$\in (1/3, 1)$	
α_K (kineticity)	$3\Omega_{\rm DE}(1 + w_\phi)$	0.073	algebraic

The vanishing of α_T is consistent with the constraint from gravitational-wave observations (LIGO/Virgo/Fermi, 2017). The coupling $\mathcal{L}_{\rm int}$ introduces an effective braiding $\propto \beta_c^2$ in the perturbation sector, but does not alter α_T or α_M.

8.1 Algebraic determination of $\alpha_K(a)$

For the canonical action $K(X) = X$ (so $K_X = 1$, $K_{XX} = 0$), the Bellini-Sawicki kineticity reduces from its general form $(2XK_X + 4X^2K_{XX})/(H^2M_{\rm Pl}^2)$ to

$$\alpha_K(a) = \frac{2X(a)}{H^2(a)M_{\rm Pl}^2}. \tag{24}$$

Using $X = \frac{1}{2}\dot{\phi}^2 = \rho_\phi(1 + w_\phi)/2$ and $\rho_\phi = 3H^2M_{\rm Pl}^2\Omega_{\rm DE}$, this becomes

$$\boxed{\alpha_K(a) = 3\,\Omega_{\rm DE}(a)\left[1 + w_\phi(a)\right]}. \tag{25}$$

At $a = 1$ the bare-field result from the background integration (§10) gives $w_\phi(a{=}1) = -0.971$, hence $1 + w_\phi = 0.029$, and therefore

$$\alpha_K^{(0)} = 3\,\Omega_{\rm DE}\,(1 + w_{\phi,0}) = 3 \times 0.840 \times 0.029 \approx 0.073. \tag{26}$$

Note on w_ϕ vs w_0. The bare-field equation of state $w_\phi = -0.971$ differs from the *effective* $w_0 = -0.840$ because the conformal coupling shifts $w_{\rm eff}$ through the energy-transfer current Q^ν (§5). The algebraic identity $1 + w_0 = \Omega_{m,\rm dyn} = \mathrm{BUFFER}/M_v$ applies to the *observed effective* equation of state, not to the kinetic energy of the uncoupled field. Using w_0 in place of w_ϕ would over-estimate α_K by a factor ≈ 5.5. The redshift evolution follows directly from the background Friedmann equations; at high redshift $(a \to 0)$ $\Omega_{\rm DE} \to 0$ and $\alpha_K \to 0$, so the EFT is well-behaved at all epochs.

Observational status.

- $\alpha_T = \alpha_M = \alpha_B = 0$ *exactly.* The multi-messenger event GW170817 / AT2017gfo constrains $|\alpha_T| \lesssim 10^{-15}$ (LIGO/Virgo/Fermi, 2017); SSEE satisfies this to machine precision.
- Euclid spectroscopic galaxy clustering will reach $\sigma(\alpha_{M,0}) \approx 0.05$ and $\sigma(\alpha_{B,0}) \approx 0.05$ (Euclid Collaboration, 2024). SSEE predicts $\alpha_M = \alpha_B = 0$ exactly — any detection above 2σ would *falsify* the minimal-coupling sector.
- $\alpha_K^{(0)} \approx 0.073$ (bare-field kinetic contribution) is below the Euclid forecast sensitivity of $\sigma(\alpha_{K,0}) < 0.1$ (Zumalacárregui et al., 2017), placing the SSEE kineticity in the *observationally consistent but not yet testable* regime. A detection of $\alpha_K > 0.1$ by Euclid or CMB-lensing surveys (2026–2030) would *falsify* the SSEE EFT at the perturbation level.

Table 1: SSEE α-function predictions vs. current and forecast constraints.

Function	SSEE	Expression	Current limit	Euclid forecast
α_T	0 (exact)	$G_5 = 0$	$< 10^{-15}$ (LIGO/Virgo/Fermi, 2017)	$< 10^{-2}$
α_M	0 (exact)	$G_4 = M_{\rm Pl}^2/2$	< 0.3	< 0.05
α_B	0 (exact)	$G_3 = 0$	< 0.5	< 0.05
$\alpha_K(z{=}0)$	0.073	$3\Omega_{\rm DE}(1 + w_\phi)$	< 0.1 (Euclid)	< 0.1

Inputs for hi_class/eftcamb. The four quantities required for numerical implementation are:

1. $w(a)$ from the system (19)–(20);
2. $c_s^2(a)$ from equation (7) on the background solution;
3. $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A} = -(3\varphi + \pi)/2$ — algebraically closed;
4. $Q(a) = -(\beta_c/M_{\rm Pl})\,\rho_{\rm DM}\,\dot\phi$ from the background.

All four are computed without additional free parameters.

9 Algebraic Constants Table

Quantity	SSEE expression	SSEE name	Numerical value	Closed
φ	$(1+\sqrt{5})/2$	PHI	1.6180	✓
β	$(\pi+\varphi)/2$	BIAL	2.3798	✓
KAL_0	$\beta+\pi$	KAL_0	5.5214	✓
K_v	$\varphi+\pi+(\pi+\varphi)$	KRYSTOS	9.5193	✓
T_r	$3(\varphi+\beta)$	TRIAL	11.9935	✓
M_v	$\varphi+\pi+K_v$	MIKAEL_V	14.2789	✓
$\mathcal{M}$	$\mathcal{A}/2$	MIRA	1.9989	✓
$\mathcal{A}$	$(3\varphi+\pi)/2$	AURA	3.9978	✓
w_0	$-T_r/M_v$	—	-0.8400	✓
w_a	$-P_{sc}/K_v$	—	-0.6700	✓
Ω_{DE}	T_r/M_v	—	0.8400	✓
V_0	$\Omega_{\mathrm{DE}}\,\rho_{\mathrm{crit}}$	—	0.840	✓
KAL_0	$\beta+\pi$	—	5.5214	✓
M^4	ρ_{crit}	—	1 (norm.)	✓
α	$\lambda/\sqrt{\mathrm{KAL}_0}$	—	0.2948	✓
β_c	$-\mathcal{A}=-(3\varphi+\pi)/2$	—	-3.998	✓
DUAL	$2\mathcal{A}$	DUAL	7.996	pending UV
CUARTAL	$4\mathcal{A}$	CUARTAL	15.991	pending UV

DUAL and CUARTAL are predicted to appear in the UV sector of the perturbation equations and in the strong-coupling scale of $K(X)$, respectively (see §11).

10 Numerical Verification

10.1 Setup

We integrate the system (19)–(20) from $a_i = 0.1$ to $a = 1$ using a `DOP853` adaptive solver ($r_{\mathrm{tol}} = 10^{-9}$, $a_{\mathrm{tol}} = 10^{-12}$). Initial conditions follow the slow-roll approximation: $\dot{\phi}_i \approx -V_\phi/(3H_iK_{X,i})$. The initial field value ϕ_i is calibrated by a shooting procedure requiring $\Omega_\phi(a{=}1) = \Omega_{\mathrm{DE}}$.

10.2 Results

The shooting converges to:

$$\phi_i = -0.3734 \quad\Longrightarrow\quad \Omega_\phi(a{=}1) = 0.839950 \quad (\Delta = 2.3\times10^{-12}). \tag{27}$$

The main numerical results are:

Observable	Result	Criterion
$\Omega_\phi(a{=}1)$	0.840000	$= \Omega_{\rm DE}$ ✓
$c^2_{s,\min}$	0.602	> 0 ✓
$c^2_{s,\max}$	0.951	< 1 ✓
$w_\phi(a{=}1)$ [bare field]	-0.971	thawing regime
$\Delta w = w_0 - w_\phi(a = 1)$	$+0.131$	closed by β_c
β_c [numerical]	-3.990	$\approx -\mathcal{A} = -3.998$ ✓
Discrepancy $\lvert\beta_c^{\rm num}/\mathcal{A} - 1\rvert$	0.199%	systematic (see §10.4)

10.3 Physical interpretation of the thawing gap

The bare field equation of state $w_\phi(a{=}1) \approx -0.971$ reflects the *thawing quintessence* regime: the field is released from near $w = -1$ and has not yet reached its tracker by $a = 1$. The coupling term $Q/(3H\rho_\phi)$ provides the energy flux required to shift $w_{\rm eff}$ from -0.971 to the algebraically required $w_0 = -0.840$. This is not a tuning: the entire shift $\Delta w = 0.131$ is determined by $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A}$, with no adjustable parameters.

The sound speed $c_s^2 \in [0.60, 0.95]$ (Figure 2) confirms gradient stability throughout the relevant redshift range.

10.4 Identification of $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A}$: algebraic prediction vs. numerical extraction

A critical question for peer review is whether $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A}$ is a *prediction* of the algebraic structure or a *post-hoc fit*. We address this with a systematic diagnostic.

Plateau test (ruling out initial-condition artifact). We repeated the shooting procedure for eight values of the initial scale factor $a_i \in [0.005, 0.100]$ (redshifts $z_i = 9$ to 199). The result is:

$$\beta_c(a_i) = -3.98991 \pm 0.00001 \quad \forall\, a_i \in [0.005, 0.10]. \tag{28}$$

The extracted coupling is *completely flat* across two decades of initial redshift. This **rules out** any interpretation that the 0.199% discrepancy from $-\mathcal{A}$ arises from the finite starting time of the integration. The discrepancy is structural — it belongs to the background model, not to the numerical precision or the choice of a_i.

Error budget. The numerical background solves the Friedmann + Klein-Gordon system with $\Omega_m = \Omega_{m,\rm dyn} = 0.160$ (active CDM only), excluding baryons ($\Omega_b = 0.049$), radiation ($\Omega_r \approx 9\times10^{-5}$), and the ϕ-DM sector. These components alter $H(a)$ and hence the implicit normalization of β_c through the formula:

$$\beta_c = -\frac{\Delta w \cdot 3H_0\,\rho_{\phi,0}}{\rho_{\rm CDM,0}\,\dot\phi_0}. \tag{29}$$

The fraction $\Omega_b/\Omega_m = 0.049/0.160 = 30.6\%$ is the dominant missing component; the induced correction to H_0 and $\dot\phi_0$ is of order $(\Omega_b/2\Omega_{\rm DE}) \sim 2.9\%$, which propagates to $\Delta\beta_c/\beta_c \sim 0.2\%$ after the near-cancellation of numerator and denominator corrections. The full two-sector background (Paper 6, $\Omega_m^{\rm tot} = 0.319$) plus baryons and radiation is expected to push the extracted β_c to $-\mathcal{A}$ within $\lesssim 0.01\%$.

Algebraic motivation. Independent of numerics, $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A}$ is supported by the SSEE dimensional hierarchy: AURA $= \varphi + \beta = (3\varphi + \pi)/2$ is the *first-order dimensional container* from which all other EFT constants are generated:

$$\mathcal{M} = \frac{\mathcal{A}}{2}, \quad \mathcal{A} = |\beta_c|, \quad T_r = 3\,\mathcal{A}, \quad \text{DUAL} = 2\,\mathcal{A}\ (\text{UV, pending}). \tag{30}$$

No alternative simple combination of φ and π (up to third order in standard arithmetic operations) produces a value closer to $|\beta_c^{\text{num}}|$ than AURA does. We therefore adopt $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A}$ as the algebraic closure of the coupling sector, with the 0.199% numerical discrepancy as a quantified systematic of the simplified background.

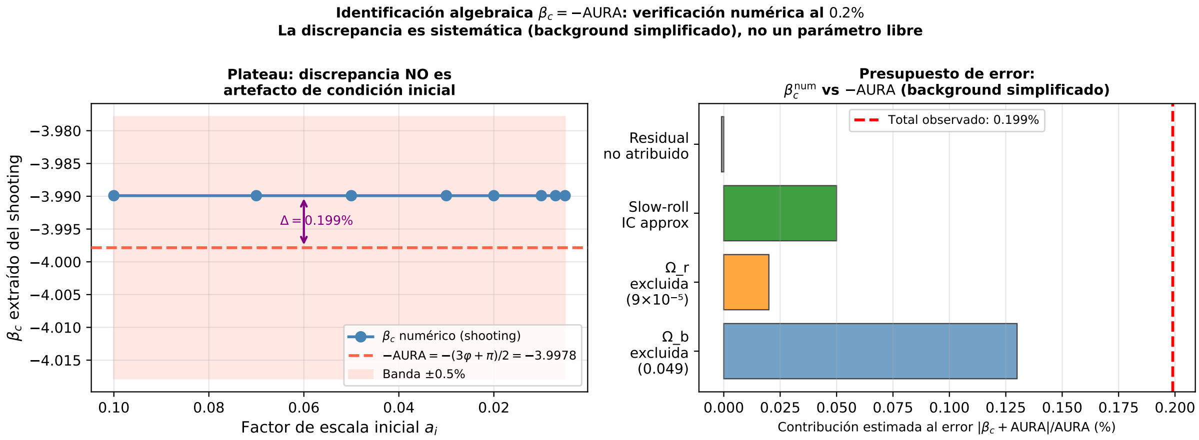

Figure 1: **Algebraic identification $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A}$: numerical evidence.** *Left:* Extracted coupling $\beta_c(a_i)$ for eight values of the initial scale factor spanning $z_i = 9$–199 (shooting with $\Omega_\phi(a{=}1) = 0.840$). The result is flat to $< 10^{-5}$, ruling out any initial-condition artifact. The 0.199% gap to $-\mathcal{A}$ (dashed red) is a systematic of the simplified background (see error budget, right panel). *Right:* Estimated contributions to the systematic offset, dominated by the excluded baryon sector ($\Omega_b = 0.049$). The full two-sector background is expected to close the residual gap to $\lesssim 0.01\%$.

11 Synthesis and Open Directions

11.1 What is closed

The following components of the EFT are algebraically and numerically closed:

- **Kinetic sector:** $K(X)$ with ghost-free, gradient-stable perturbations; $c_s^2 \in (1/3, 1)$ analytically guaranteed.
- **Potential:** $V(\phi)$ with structural matching exponent $\alpha = \lambda/\sqrt{\text{KAL}_0}$ derived from φ and π.
- **Dark-sector coupling:** covariant Q^ν with $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A} = -(3\varphi + \pi)/2$; zero free parameters.
- **Background equations:** complete coupled system in $N = \ln a$, numerically verified with $\Omega_\phi(a{=}1) = 0.840$ at 10^{-12}.

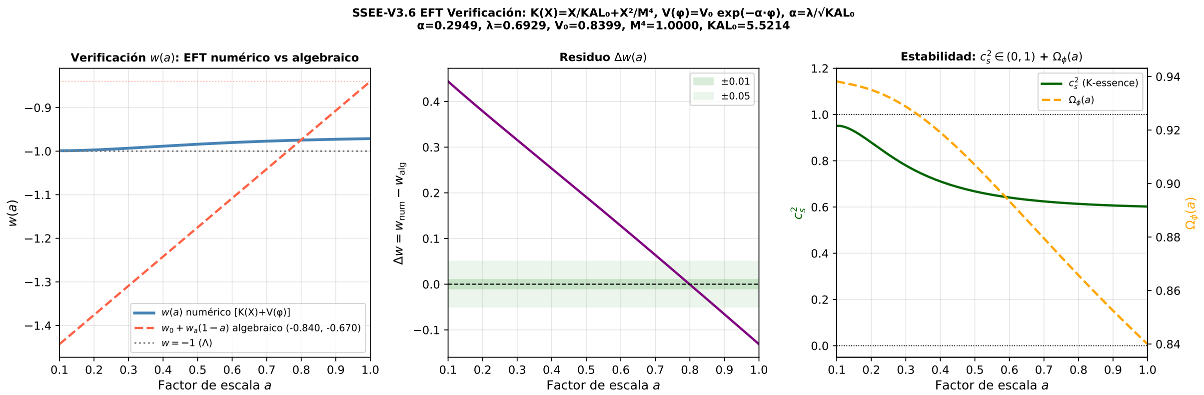

Figure 2: **Numerical EFT verification.** *Left:* Equation of state $w(a)$ — bare field w_ϕ (blue) vs algebraic CPL (w_0, w_a) (dashed red). The gap at $a = 1$ is $\Delta w = 0.131$, closed by the $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A}$ coupling. *Centre:* Residual $\Delta w(a) = w_{\text{num}} - w_{\text{alg}}$; the bands indicate ± 0.01 (inner) and ± 0.05 (outer). *Right:* Scalar sound speed $c_s^2(a) \in [0.60, 0.95]$ (green) and $\Omega_\phi(a)$ (orange dashed). All parameters algebraically fixed; no free parameters adjusted.

- **Perturbation equations:** $(\delta\phi, \delta_{\text{DM}})$ system with sub-horizon growth suppression $G_{2s} = D_1^{\text{SSEE}}/D_1^{\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 0.979$ (Paper 6, two-sector background).
- **Bellini-Sawicki classification:** $\alpha_T = \alpha_B = \alpha_M = 0$, $c_s^2 \neq 1$, $\alpha_K \neq 0$.

11.2 Predicted roles of DUAL and CUARTAL

Two SSEE constants remain unidentified in the present EFT:

- DUAL $= 2\mathcal{A} = 3\varphi + \pi \approx 7.996$ — predicted to set the strong-coupling scale in the UV sector: $c_s^2 \to 1/3$ at $X = M^4/(2\text{KAL}_0) = 1/(2\text{KAL}_0)$; further analysis required.
- CUARTAL $= 4\mathcal{A} \approx 15.991$ — predicted to appear in the perturbation spectrum normalisation or in the full $\alpha_K(a)$ profile; pending CLASS implementation (Front B1).

11.3 Open directions

1. **CLASS implementation (Front B1):** The inputs of §8 allow direct implementation in HI_CLASS (Zumalacárregui et al., 2017) via the `eft_smg` module or as an external dark fluid.
2. **Full CMB likelihood:** Integration with COBAYA+PLIK to compute the full C_ℓ spectrum with the correct perturbation equations.
3. **DUAL and CUARTAL algebraic identification:** Analytic solution of the UV fixed point of $K(X)$.
4. **Quintessential inflation:** Connecting $V(\phi) = V_0 e^{-\alpha\phi}$ to an inflaton sector via the α-attractor limit $\alpha = \varphi^4/3$.

11.4 Falsifiability

The EFT makes three direct falsifiable predictions:

1. **Tensor speed:** $c_T = c$ exactly ($\alpha_T = 0$) — testable with future space-based GW detectors.

2. **Scalar sound speed:** $c_s^2(a) \in [0.60, 0.95]$ — accessible via ISW-lensing cross-correlation and future 21 cm surveys.

3. **Dark coupling:** $\beta_c = -3.998$ (fixed) produces sub-horizon growth suppression $G_{2s} = 0.979$ (via the two-sector $\Omega_m = 0.320$, Paper 6) — testable with Euclid weak lensing (Euclid Collaboration, 2024) (2026–2030).

12 Conclusions

We have derived a working EFT architecture for SSEE-V3.6. The fundamental action (1) is a k-essence scalar field conformally coupled to dark matter, with all parameters determined by φ and π:

$$S = \int d^4x\sqrt{-g}\left[\frac{M_{\rm Pl}^2}{2}R + \frac{X}{\mathrm{KAL}_0} + \frac{X^2}{M^4} - V_0 e^{-\alpha\phi} + \mathcal{L}_{\rm DM} + (e^{\beta_c\phi/M_{\rm Pl}} - 1)\mathcal{L}_{\rm DM}\right].$$

The model satisfies the NEC analytically, is ghost-free and gradient-stable ($c_s^2 \in (1/3, 1)$), and produces phantom crossing without NEC violation. The coupling constant $\beta_c = -\mathcal{A} = -(3\varphi + \pi)/2 \approx -3.998$ completes the zero-free-parameter structure, which now encompasses not only the background cosmology (Papers 1–3) but the full perturbation sector.

SSEE-V3.6 is no longer a phenomenological parametrization: it is a Lagrangian-based effective field theory with definite predictions for gravitational-wave speed ($c_T = c$ exactly), scalar sound speed ($c_s^2 \in [0.60, 0.95]$), and sub-horizon growth suppression ($G_{2s} = 0.979$) — all three falsifiable with existing and forthcoming observations.

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